



“ Naveen Patnaik as Steel and Mines Minister had granted Indrani Patnaik ‘prospective lease’ In 2008, she was granted surface rights to operate mines. ”

NARASINGH MISHRA, Senior Congress leader

“ The humiliating defeat in the elections has led the opposition parties to launch a smear campaign against the Naveen Patnaik Government. ”

PYRIMOHAN MOHAPATRA, Senior BJD leader



“ Either the system has crumbled or everyone from the Secretariat to the miners is involved. This is the biggest scam in post-Independence India. ”

RABI DAS, Activist and petitioner

decade, an allegation challenged by the company as “far from truth”.

State Vigilance Director Anup Patnaik says the Government has asked them to be ruthless and spare none. “We have been given a free hand to raid any mine or persons including their political bosses without fear or pressure.” The directorate has also filed an FIR against Ram Bahadur Thakur Ltd which was never given a lease and raided the mines and offices of S.R. Rungta and Indrani besides others. The directorate is also inquiring into the activities of the state-owned Orissa Mining Corporation (OMC). A task force set up by the Government has Mines Secretary and OMC Chairman Ashok Dalwai as its convener, and few are convinced that there will be an honest inquiry. Dalwai, however, rubbishes the charge and doesn’t agree with the word “scam”. But Anup points to the violation of laws relating to forests, mines, environment besides the applicability of certain sections of the IPC and CrPC. Then there was the faulty transit permit system that gave a free hand to mine owners, for it is the min-

ers who are allowed to print transit form for officials to sign.

However, the manner in which a recent India Bureau of Mines (IBM) inquiry into the allegations of illegal mining in Keonjhar and Sundergarh districts was stopped midway has raised suspicions. Das has complained to the Union Ministry of Mines: “We want to know the reasons for withdrawal of the probe team. We strongly believe that the IBM has directly and indirectly helped large-scale illegal mining in Orissa.”

BJP leader Bijoy Mohapatra asks, “How can Naveen Patnaik claim ignorance? Every day some 18,000 trucks move in Keonjhar. Forests were destroyed and wildlife was disturbed. Officials and ministers knew it. Only Naveen Patnaik did not know. Is he the chief minister or a blindfolded king?” Bijoy adds, “Every tenth person in Bhubaneswar is driving an SUV, Audi, BMW or Mercedes, and people think it is because of industrialisation which never happened. Instead, poverty has deepened.” He could be right: according to the Tendulkar Committee report, about 57.2 per cent people of the

state are poor.

The black economy generated by the illegal mining is also reflected in the spending pattern of BJD candidates during the Assembly elections. “Where did this money come from? And we found out that all the money had come from mines. It is the biggest scam in post-Independence India,” says Das. It was also alleged that Pyarimohan, the chief architect of the BJD’s massive victory, had flown to Joda mines before the elections in a helicopter provided by Triveni Earth-Movers. Pyarimohan laughs at the suggestion that he went there to collect funds and says, “I pity those who don’t understand the mechanism of election. Do you think I will go out openly to collect funds? I met the mine owners in the inaccessible areas to ask them to perform their social responsibility and start peripheral development works, in the interest of the state and in their own. Besides, I had hired a helicopter and paid for it.”

As more skeletons start tumbling out of the closet with each passing day, an impartial probe will hold the key to exposing the real culprits. ■